POWER BI · LESSON 3 OF 8

DAX Fundamentals: Measures, Filter Context & CALCULATE

Learn DAX, the formula language of Power BI. Understand calculated columns vs measures, row context vs filter context, write core aggregations and iterators (SUMX), master CALCULATE and FILTER, ALL/REMOVEFILTERS and ALLSELECTED, handle division safely, use variables, and build a library of business measures.

Power BI classes 2–3 | Power BI Desktop 2026 | Intermediate | 150 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Explain the difference between a calculated column and a measure, and when to use each
- Describe row context and filter context and predict what a measure returns in a visual
- Write aggregation measures and iterators (SUM, COUNTROWS, DISTINCTCOUNT, SUMX, AVERAGEX)
- Use CALCULATE with filter arguments, ALL/REMOVEFILTERS and ALLSELECTED to build ratios and percent-of-total
- Use variables, DIVIDE, IF/SWITCH and display folders to write clean, reusable measures

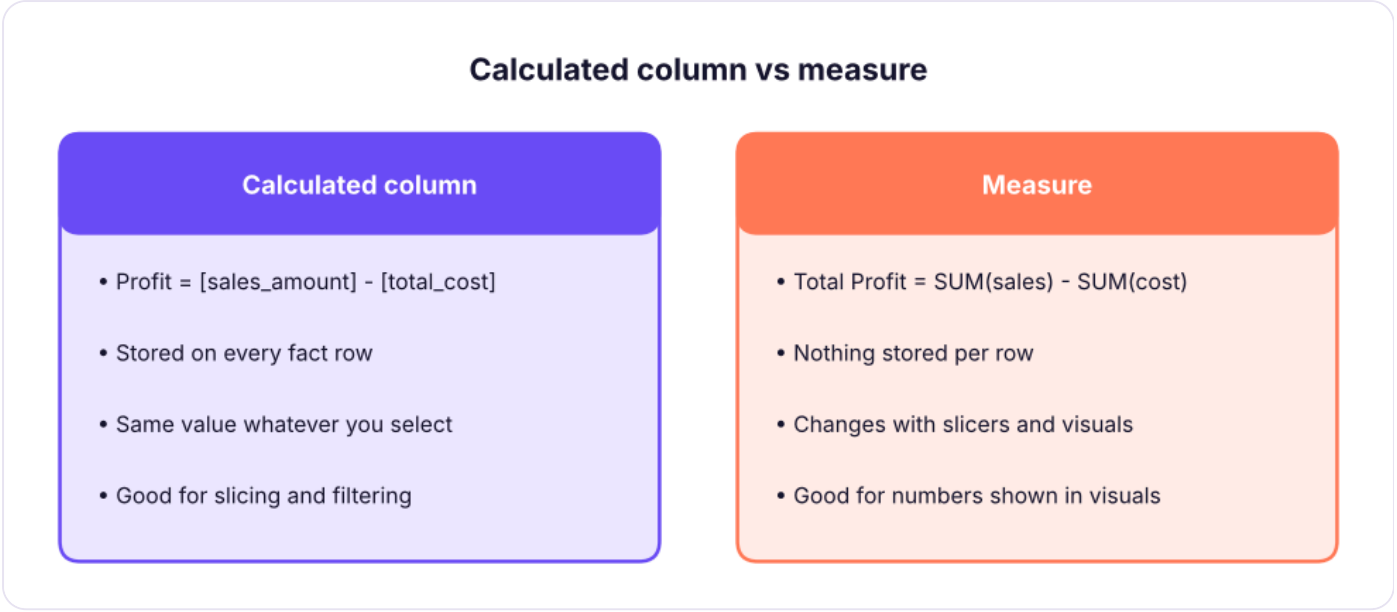
Datasets used

`adventure_cycles/fact_sales.csv` `adventure_cycles/dim_product.csv` `adventure_cycles/dim_territory.csv` `hr_employees.csv`

What is DAX?

DAX (Data Analysis Expressions) is the formula language used in Power BI, Excel's Data Model and Analysis Services. It looks like Excel formulas, but it works on **columns and tables** and recalculates for whatever the user selects in a visual. DAX is the skill that separates a report builder from a Power BI developer.

	Calculated column	Measure
Evaluated	**Row by row** when data is refreshed	**On the fly**, for the current filter selection
Stored in the model	Yes (uses memory)	No (only the formula)
Result depends on slicers?	No	**Yes**
Use for	New attributes to slice by (Age Band, Hire Year, Profit per row)	Totals, ratios, KPIs, growth
Appears in	Rows, columns, slicers, filters	Values area, cards, tooltips



The same table, two ways. A calculated column adds a value to every row. A measure returns one number computed from whichever rows are currently filtered.

> **TIP** **Rule of thumb**
>
> If you want to **put it on an axis or slicer**, make a column. If you want to **put it in the Values well**, make a measure. In a star schema, almost every number is a measure.

DAX syntax in five minutes

```DAX
Total Sales = SUM ( fact_sales[sales_amount] )
```

- `Total Sales` is the **measure name** (spaces allowed, no brackets when defining it).
- `=` starts the formula.
- `SUM` is a **function**; `fact_sales[sales_amount]` is a **fully qualified column** (table name, then column in square brackets). Always include the table name for columns; **never** include it for measures: `[Total Sales]`.
- Strings use double quotes; comments use `--` or `//` or `/* … */`.
- Operators: `+ - * /`, `&` (join text), `= <> > < ≥ ≤`, `&&` (AND), `||` (OR), `IN { "A", "B" }`.
- Spaces and line breaks are ignored; format with **daxformatter.com** or the formatting button.

Creating measures

Home → **New measure** (or right-click a table). Put all measures in an empty table named `_Measures` (Home → Enter data → name `_Measures` → Load, then hide its default column) so they are easy to find. Use **display folders** (Model view → Properties) to group them.

Basic aggregations

```DAX
Total Sales      = SUM ( fact_sales[sales_amount] )
Total Cost       = SUM ( fact_sales[total_cost] )
Total Profit     = [Total Sales] - [Total Cost]
Profit Margin %  = DIVIDE ( [Total Profit], [Total Sales] )
Units Sold       = SUM ( fact_sales[quantity] )
Orders           = DISTINCTCOUNT ( fact_sales[order_number] )
Order Lines      = COUNTROWS ( fact_sales )
Avg Order Value  = DIVIDE ( [Total Sales], [Orders] )     -- in this data every order has
one line, so Orders = Order Lines
Customers        = DISTINCTCOUNT ( fact_sales[customer_key] )
```

Check the values in Python; they are what a card visual with no filters would display:

Python

```python
import pandas as pd
D = "adventure_cycles/"
f = pd.read_csv(D + "fact_sales.csv", parse_dates=["order_date"]); p = pd.read_csv(D +
"dim_product.csv"); t = pd.read_csv(D + "dim_territory.csv")
sales, cost = f.sales_amount.sum(), f.total_cost.sum()
print(f"Total Sales     : {sales:,.0f}")
print(f"Total Cost      : {cost:,.0f}")
print(f"Total Profit    : {sales - cost:,.0f}")
print(f"Profit Margin % : {(sales - cost) / sales:.1%}")
print(f"Units Sold      : {f.quantity.sum():,}")
print(f"Orders          : {f.order_number.nunique():,}")
print(f"Order Lines     : {len(f):,}")
print(f"Avg Order Value : {sales / f.order_number.nunique():,.0f}")
print(f"Customers       : {f.customer_key.nunique():,}")
```

OUTPUT

```
Total Sales     : 594,559,665
Total Cost      : 384,392,790
Total Profit    : 210,166,875
Profit Margin % : 35.3%
Units Sold      : 22,703
Orders          : 9,000
Order Lines     : 9,000
Avg Order Value : 66,062
Customers       : 1,200
```

WATCH OUT **DIVIDE, not /**

`[A] / [B]` returns an error or infinity when B is 0 or blank. `DIVIDE ( [A], [B] )` returns BLANK (or an alternate result: `DIVIDE ( [A], [B], 0 )`). Always use DIVIDE for ratios.

Filter context: the heart of DAX

When you put a measure in a visual, DAX evaluates it **once per cell**, with a **filter context** made of everything that filters the data for that cell: row and column headers, slicers, page/report filters, and cross-filtering from other visuals.



Filter context for one cell of a matrix (Category = Bikes, Country = India, Year = 2025 slicer). DAX applies all of them to the fact table before it sums.

Same measure, different context in each cell. The matrix below is exactly what Power BI shows for `Total Sales` with Category on rows and Country on columns:

Python

```
m = f.merge(p, on="product_key").merge(t, on="territory_key")
m["year"] = m.order_date.dt.year
print((m.pivot_table(index="category", columns="country", values="sales_amount",
aggfunc="sum") / 1e6).round(1).to_string())
print("\nSame measure, with a Year = 2025 slicer:")
print((m[m.year == 2025].pivot_table(index="category", columns="country",
values="sales_amount", aggfunc="sum") / 1e6).round(1).to_string())
```

OUTPUT

```
country      India  Singapore   UAE
category
Accessories    6.7        1.7   1.3
Bikes        320.6       74.8  71.3
Clothing       6.0        1.3   1.1
Components    73.5       18.8  17.2

Same measure, with a Year = 2025 slicer:
country      India  Singapore   UAE
category
Accessories    2.2        0.7   0.4
Bikes        102.3       24.6  22.0
Clothing       2.0        0.3   0.4
Components    22.9        7.1   5.1
```

Row context

A **row context** exists when DAX goes through a table row by row: in a **calculated column**, and inside **iterator** functions (`SUMX` , `AVERAGEX` , `FILTER` ...). In row context, column references mean "this row's value".

DAX

```
-- Calculated column on fact_sales: row context gives each row's own values
Line Profit = fact_sales[sales_amount] - fact_sales[total_cost]
```

Row context does **not** automatically filter other tables; **CALCULATE** converts a row context into a filter context ("context transition").

Iterators: SUMX, AVERAGEX, MAXX

`SUM ( column )` adds one column. When you need to **calculate per row first** and then aggregate, use an iterator: `SUMX ( table, expression )`.

DAX

```
-- Revenue at list price (unit_price x quantity), calculated row by row
List Value = SUMX ( fact_sales, fact_sales[quantity] * fact_sales[unit_price] )

-- Average margin per order line (not the same as total profit / total sales!)
Avg Line Margin % = AVERAGEX ( fact_sales, DIVIDE ( fact_sales[sales_amount] -
fact_sales[total_cost], fact_sales[sales_amount] ) )

-- Most profitable single line
Max Line Profit = MAXX ( fact_sales, fact_sales[sales_amount] - fact_sales[total_cost] )
```

Python

```
f["line_profit"] = f.sales_amount - f.total_cost
list_value = (f.quantity * f.unit_price).sum()
avg_line_margin = ((f.sales_amount - f.total_cost) / f.sales_amount).mean()
print(f"List Value        : {list_value:,.0f}")
print(f"Realised/List     : {f.sales_amount.sum() / list_value:.1%}  (average price
realisation)")
print(f"Avg Line Margin % : {avg_line_margin:.1%}   vs overall margin
{(f.sales_amount.sum() - f.total_cost.sum()) / f.sales_amount.sum():.1%}")
print(f"Max Line Profit   : {f.line_profit.max():,.0f}")
```

OUTPUT

```
List Value        : 617,201,300
Realised/List     : 96.3%  (average price realisation)
Avg Line Margin % : 34.5%   vs overall margin 35.3%
Max Line Profit   : 174,060
```

The average of line margins (34.5%) differs slightly from the overall margin (35.3%) because large lines count more in the total than in a simple average. Choose the definition the business wants, and

name the measure clearly.

CALCULATE: change the filter context

`CALCULATE ( expression, filter1, filter2, … )` evaluates the expression in a **modified** filter context. It is the most important DAX function.

DAX

```
Bike Sales   = CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], dim_product[category] = "Bikes" )
India Sales  = CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], dim_territory[country] = "India" )
Bike Sales India 2025 =
    CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], dim_product[category] = "Bikes", dim_territory[country] =
"India", dim_date[year] = 2025 )
High Value Lines = CALCULATE ( COUNTROWS ( fact_sales ), fact_sales[sales_amount] > 200000
)
```

Multiple filter arguments are combined with **AND**. A simple column filter like `dim_product[category] = "Bikes"` **replaces** any existing filter on that column.

Python

```
bike = f.merge(p, on="product_key").query("category == 'Bikes'").sales_amount.sum()
print(f"Bike Sales          : {bike:,.0f}")
india_2025_bikes = m[(m.category == "Bikes") & (m.country == "India") & (m.year ==
2025)].sales_amount.sum()
print(f"Bike Sales India 2025: {india_2025_bikes:,.0f}")
print(f"High Value Lines    : {(f.sales_amount > 200000).sum():,}")
```

OUTPUT

```
Bike Sales          : 466,754,465
Bike Sales India 2025: 102,271,520
High Value Lines    : 797
```

Filter functions: ALL, REMOVEFILTERS, ALLSELECTED, ALLEXCEPT, KEEPFILTERS

Function	Effect	Typical use
`ALL ( table or column )` / `REMOVEFILTERS ( … )`	Ignores filters on the table/column	Grand totals, denominators
`ALLSELECTED ( … )`	Ignores filters from the visual's own rows/columns but keeps slicers and page filters	"% of visible total"
`ALLEXCEPT ( table, col1, … )`	Removes all filters on the table except those columns	Subtotals per group
`VALUES ( column )`	The distinct values visible in the current context	Counting / looping over what is filtered
`SELECTEDVALUE ( column, alt )`	The single selected value (or alternate)	Titles, dynamic measures
`KEEPFILTERS ( filter )`	Intersects with, rather than replaces, existing filters	Advanced

Percent of total

DAX

```
Sales % of Total =
DIVIDE ( [Total Sales], CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], REMOVEFILTERS ( dim_product ) ) )

Sales % of Visible Total =
DIVIDE ( [Total Sales], CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], ALLSELECTED ( dim_product ) ) )

Share Within Country =
DIVIDE ( [Total Sales], CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], ALLEXCEPT ( dim_territory,
dim_territory[country] ) ) )
```

Python

```
cat = m.groupby("category").sales_amount.sum()
print((100 * cat / cat.sum()).round(1).rename("Sales % of Total").to_string())
```

OUTPUT

```
category
Accessories     1.6
Bikes          78.5
```

```
Clothing        1.4
Components     18.4
```

FILTER: row-by-row conditions

`FILTER ( table, condition )` is an iterator that returns the rows where the condition is TRUE. Use it when a filter needs a **measure or several columns**; for a simple single-column comparison, the plain `column = value` form inside CALCULATE is faster.

DAX

```dax
-- Sales from products with a list price above 1,00,000
Premium Sales = CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], FILTER ( dim_product, dim_product[list_price] > 100000 ) )

-- Number of products whose total sales beat 1 crore
Strong Products = COUNTROWS ( FILTER ( VALUES ( dim_product[product] ), [Total Sales] > 10000000 ) )
```

Python

```python
prem = f.merge(p, on="product_key").query("list_price > 100000").sales_amount.sum()
ps = f.groupby("product_key").sales_amount.sum()
print(f"Premium Sales  : {prem:,.0f}")
print(f"Strong Products: {(ps > 10_000_000).sum()}  (products with sales above ₹1 crore)")
```

OUTPUT

```
Premium Sales  : 303,639,995
Strong Products: 20  (products with sales above ₹1 crore)
```

Variables and readability

`VAR … RETURN` stores intermediate results: easier to read, easier to debug, and faster (each variable is evaluated once).

DAX

```dax
Profit Margin vs Overall =
VAR CurrentMargin = DIVIDE ( [Total Profit], [Total Sales] )
VAR OverallMargin = CALCULATE ( DIVIDE ( [Total Profit], [Total Sales] ), REMOVEFILTERS () )
RETURN
    CurrentMargin - OverallMargin
```

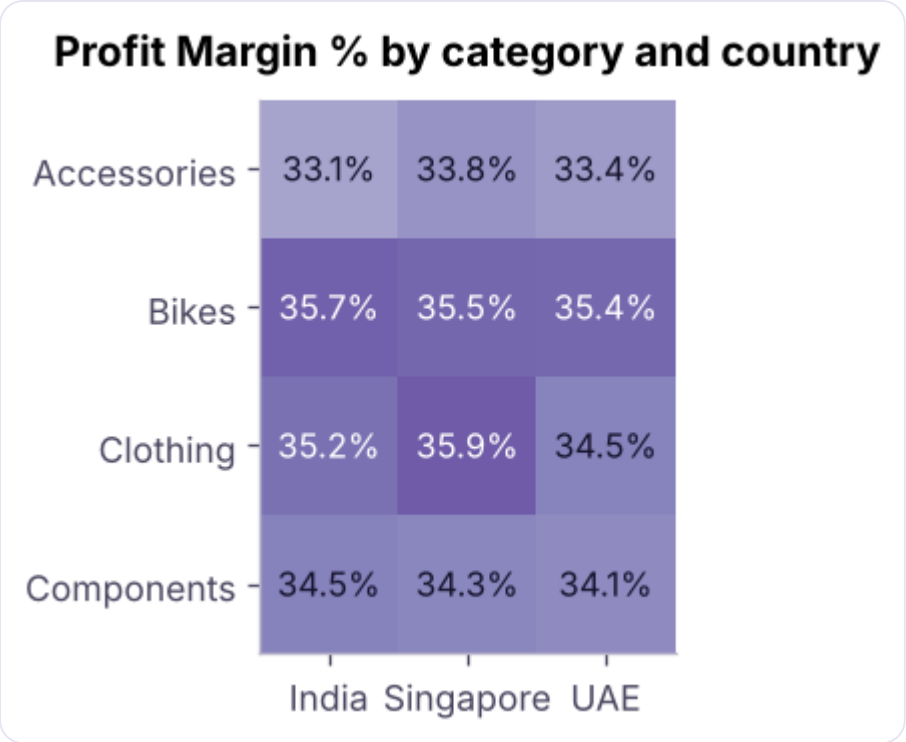
Logical and text measures

```dax
Margin Status =
SWITCH (
    TRUE (),
    ISBLANK ( [Profit Margin %] ), "No data",
    [Profit Margin %] ⩾ 0.4,      "Excellent",
    [Profit Margin %] ⩾ 0.3,      "Good",
    "Review"
)

Selected Country Title =
"Sales for " & SELECTEDVALUE ( dim_territory[country], "all countries" )
```

Function	Purpose
`IF ( test, a, b )`, `SWITCH ( expr, v1, r1, … )`, `SWITCH ( TRUE (), cond1, r1, … )`	Branching
`ISBLANK`, `COALESCE ( x, 0 )`, `BLANK ()`	Handle empty values
`HASONE ( col )`, `ISFILTERED ( col )`	Test the current context
`FORMAT ( value, "0.0%" )`, `CONCATENATEX ( table, col, ", " )`	Text

Measures in action: a profit-margin matrix



Profit margin % by category and country: the matrix you would build with the Profit Margin % measure and conditional formatting (darker = higher).

Common DAX mistakes

Mistake	Fix
Using a calculated column where a measure is needed (results do not respond to slicers)	Create a measure
Dividing with `/`	`DIVIDE`
Writing `SUM ( [Measure] )`	`SUM` takes columns; use `SUMX ( table, [Measure] )` for measures over rows
Averaging ratios (`AVERAGE` of a margin column)	Compute `DIVIDE ( SUM numerator, SUM denominator )` unless you really want the average of ratios
Using `FILTER ( ALL ( table ), … )` when a column filter works	Prefer simple column filters inside CALCULATE
Forgetting that a measure's result depends on context; testing in a card	Test in a table or matrix with the fields you care about
Hard-coding values (`"Bikes"`) in many measures	Use a parameter table or SELECTEDVALUE

DO IT WITH AI

Do it with AI

Copilot and chat assistants write decent DAX, but they invent column names and often misuse context. A reliable prompt gives the **exact table and column names**, the **relationships**, and the **expected result**: *"Tables: fact_sales(order_date, product_key, sales_amount, total_cost), dim_product(product_key, category), dim_date(date). Write a DAX measure for each category's share of total sales that ignores the category filter but respects year slicers. Explain the filter context."* Then test the measure in a table next to your own pandas check.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Calculated columns** run row by row at refresh and are stored; **measures** run at query time in the current **filter context**.
- Filter context = row/column headers + slicers + filters + cross-filtering; measures are re-evaluated for every cell.
- Row context exists in calculated columns and iterators (`SUMX` , `AVERAGEX` , `FILTER`); `CALCULATE` converts it to filter context.
- `CALCULATE ( expression, filters )` changes the filters; `REMOVEFILTERS` / `ALL` , `ALLSELECTED` , `ALLEXCEPT` remove them for percent-of-total calculations.
- Use `DIVIDE` , variables (`VAR … RETURN`), `SWITCH ( TRUE (), … )` , clear names, a `_Measures` table and display folders.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Which is evaluated for every cell of a matrix based on slicers and row/column headers?

A A calculated column

B A measure

C A relationship

D A parameter

Answer: B. Measures respond to filter context; calculated columns are fixed at refresh.

2. Which function lets you compute a total that ignores the Category filter (for a denominator)?

A `SUM`

B `CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], REMOVEFILTERS ( dim_product[category] ) )`

C `FILTER ( [Total Sales] )`

D `COUNTROWS`

Answer: B. REMOVEFILTERS (or ALL) clears the filter inside CALCULATE.

3. Which is the safest way to compute a margin?

A `[Profit] / [Sales]`

B `DIVIDE ( [Profit], [Sales] )`

C `IF ( [Sales] = 0, 0, [Profit] ) / [Sales]`

D `SUM ( [Profit] ) / SUM ( [Sales] )`

Answer: B. DIVIDE handles zero and blank denominators gracefully.

4. `SUMX ( fact_sales, fact_sales[quantity] * fact_sales[unit_price] )` **is needed because:**

A SUM cannot add numbers

B The product must be calculated per row before adding

C SUMX is faster than SUM

D It creates a calculated column

Answer: B. SUM works on one existing column; SUMX evaluates an expression per row.

5. What is row context?

A The current row being evaluated in a calculated column or iterator

B The filters from slicers

C The relationship direction

D A table filter

Answer: A. Row context refers to "this row" during row-by-row evaluation.

6. What does `CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], dim_product[category] = "Bikes" )` **return in a visual that shows each country?**

A Total sales for all products

B Bike sales for each country in the visual

C Bike sales for all countries on every row

D An error

Answer: B. The Category filter is replaced by Bikes, while the Country filter from the visual still applies.

EXERCISE **Write the measures**

Using the Adventure Cycles model, write DAX for: (1) Profit and margin % for **Clothing** only; (2) each country's share of total sales (works in a visual with country on rows); (3) the number of customers who bought more than one product line; (4) a title measure that says "Top category: ..." for the category with the highest sales in the current context.

Show solution (worked answer)

DAX

```
-- (1)
Clothing Profit  = CALCULATE ( [Total Profit], dim_product[category] = "Clothing" )
Clothing Margin  = DIVIDE ( [Clothing Profit], CALCULATE ( [Total Sales],
dim_product[category] = "Clothing" ) )
-- (2)
Country Share = DIVIDE ( [Total Sales], CALCULATE ( [Total Sales], REMOVEFILTERS (
dim_territory ) ) )
-- (3)
Multi-line Customers =
COUNTROWS ( FILTER ( VALUES ( fact_sales[customer_key] ), CALCULATE ( COUNTROWS (
fact_sales ) ) > 1 ) )
-- (4)
Top Category =
VAR t = ADDCOLUMNS ( VALUES ( dim_product[category] ), "@s", [Total Sales] )
VAR top1 = TOPN ( 1, t, [@s], DESC )
RETURN "Top category: " & MAXX ( top1, dim_product[category] )
```

Verify each in a table visual next to a pandas check.

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: What is the difference between a calculated column and a measure? A column is computed per row at refresh and stored; a measure is computed at query time for the current filter context and returns a single value.

Q: Explain filter context and row context. Filter context is the set of filters (axes, slicers, filters) applied to the model when a measure is evaluated. Row context is the "current row" while iterating a table (calculated columns, iterators). CALCULATE turns row context into filter context.

Q: What does CALCULATE do? Evaluates an expression in a modified filter context; its filter arguments add, replace or remove filters.

Q: ALL vs ALLSELECTED? ALL removes all filters from the specified table/column (grand total); ALLSELECTED removes only the filters coming from the visual's own rows and columns but keeps outer filters such as slicers, giving a total of what is visible.

Q: SUM vs SUMX? SUM adds a column; SUMX evaluates an expression for each row of a table and sums the results (needed for products of columns, conditional logic per row).

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.